The Complete Idiot's Guide to What This All Means

CAD versus Revit in plain English, on one page. Every number here is the report's number, from Deltek, not from counting folders.

THE THREE THINGS TO KNOW

1 · HOW MUCH CAD

23% of drafting hours, this year

CAD and Revit jobs only. It was 54% in 2019. The switch to Revit happened in 2020–2021 and stuck. About one drafting hour in four is still CAD.

2 · WHO MAKES MONEY

-18% CAD · **19%** Revit

On finished residential jobs we can measure properly, CAD jobs lost about 18 cents of every dollar billed; Revit jobs made about 19 cents. Typical job: -25% CAD, 27% Revit.

3 · JOBS, NOT WORK

63% of jobs · 39% of billings

CAD is most of our residential job count but well under half of the money. Counting folders with a .dwg in them counts jobs. The books weigh them.

IF SOMEONE SAYS… THE BOOKS SAY…

"More than half our residential jobs are CAD."	True by count (63% of tagged jobs with hours). By billings it is 39%, and by drafting hours this year 24%. The median CAD job is $50K of fee; the median Revit job $175K.
"CAD jobs are fine, they've always made money."	The old ones look like they did, because Deltek's timesheets only start in 2019: a job billed before then has all its billings but only part of its hours, so its margin reads high (46% on 138 CAD jobs, 36% on 73 Revit). Not real numbers for either tool, so they are left out. Jobs started since: CAD -18%, Revit 19%.
"It's just that CAD jobs are small."	Partly. Small jobs lose money on both tools: started 2020 on and under $100K, CAD -28% on 65 jobs, Revit -67% on 18. Most recent CAD work is small jobs (65 of 75). In the $100K–$300K band, started 2020 on: CAD 10% on 8, Revit 19% on 27.
"One bad year."	Calendar 2020–2025, residential CAD jobs billed $9.4M against $11.6M of labour, below zero in 5 of 6 years. Revit: $21.6M against $19.9M, below zero in 2.
"Partners' time is free, so the margins are wrong."	Partners are counted at $250 an hour, the firm's standing policy, which is 75% of all the labour cost here. At payroll instead, both margins jump (56% CAD, 62% Revit), CAD more, because partners put more hours on CAD jobs. Either way, Revit is ahead.
"So Revit makes us money and CAD loses it."	That is what the association shows. It does not prove the software caused it: job size, era, client and who ran the job travel with the tool. Treat it as a strong signal, not a verdict.

WHAT "MARGIN" MEANS HERE

What we billed, minus what the people on the job cost at the time, staff at actual payroll and partners at $250 an hour. Before overhead and subconsultants. It is a way to compare CAD and Revit, not the firm's profit and loss.

WHAT IT CANNOT TELL YOU

Anything before 2019. Anything about the 1,048 of 2,329 jobs with no drafting-type tag in Deltek. Whether a job that moved from CAD to Revit mid-way is counted right (it counts where Deltek put it). Why: it shows the pattern, not the cause.

HOW TO READ THE BIG REPORT

Page 1 is the whole story. The rest is the evidence.

Every table says which jobs it counts and why. Every assumption is listed on the last page so it can be argued with. The workbook has every job.